

CORE FORMULA

Situation -> Task -> Action -> Result -> Situation: what was going on. "Two weeks from launch, our main supplier pulled out." -> **Task:** what you were responsible for. "I owned delivery, so it was on me to hold the date." -> **Action:** what you actually did. "I called three vendors, negotiated a rush order, and re-sequenced the build." -> **Result:** what changed. "We shipped on time and the client renewed."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Silently order your example as Situation, Task, Action, Result, then say it in plain language — keep the scene to a sentence and never name the framework out loud.

BEST FOR

- Interviews and competency questions
- Performance reviews and self-assessments
- Telling a concise, concrete story
- Giving evidence for a skill you have claimed
- Sharing a lesson learnt from experience
- Making a meeting contribution land clearly
- Written updates someone needs to scan

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Quick openers

- "Let me give you a quick example."
- "Short version: here's what happened and how it turned out."
- "Can I walk you through one specific case?"
- "Let me make this concrete."
- "Give me thirty seconds and I'll show you what I mean."
- "Here's the example rather than the theory."
- "One story shows this best."

The four beats · Step signposts

- "The situation was..."
- "What I had to do was..."
- "So what I did was..."
- "And the result was..."
- "Where this started..."
- "The upshot was..."
- "Context first, then what I did, then how it landed."

Interview & review · Evidence of skill

- "You asked for a time I handled that — here's one."
- "In my last role I owned a problem end to end."
- "The measurable result was..."
- "What I took from that was..."
- "That's the clearest example I can give of that skill."
- "Happy to go deeper on any part of that."

- "When I say I improved that, here's the specific case."

Keep it human · So it isn't robotic

- "I'll keep this human, not a case study."
- "Bear with me — there's a little context first."
- "The part I'm proud of is what came out of it."
- "It mattered to me because..."
- "Stop me once you've heard enough detail."
- "Here's the short version if you're pressed for time."

Email & written · Scannable layout

- "I've laid it out as context, action and outcome so it's easy to scan."
- "Headline first, then the detail underneath."
- "Two lines of background, three bullets on what I did, one line on the result."
- "The outcome is in the first line; the rest is supporting detail."
- "Each paragraph is labelled so you can jump to what you need."

Recover & simplify · When it lands badly

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "Let me skip the background and get to what actually happened."
- "I over-explained there — the key point is the result."
- "That came out rehearsed. Here's the honest version."
- "Tell me if you'd rather I just gave you the short answer."

Under pressure · Difficult conversations

- "Let me lay out what happened plainly, then you can respond."
- "One sentence on the situation, then what I did, then where it stands."
- "Here's the context, the call I made, and the outcome — no spin."
- "Before we react, can I set out how this unfolded?"
- "I'll stick to the sequence so we're working from the same facts."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Recites STAR as a visible script and sounds rehearsed.
Better: Uses STAR silently to organise a concise answer.
Best: Uses STAR flexibly, then checks the listener is clearer, more heard and better able to respond.
2. Weak: Front-loads endless situation and background.
Better: Trims the scene to a sentence or two.
Best: Spends most of the airtime on action and result, where the value is.
3. Weak: Forces a structured story into an emotional moment.
Better: Notices the emotion and pauses the framework.
Best: Validates first, then offers structure only if it still helps.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest one-line version and drop the detail.

""Short version: the supplier fell through, I found three alternatives, we shipped on time.""

If The listener is upset or needs support

Validate first and delay the framework.

""That sounds hard. Do you want to talk it through, or hear how I'd approach it?""

If The listener wants a story or evidence

Give the full STAR example — scene brief, result concrete.

""Let me walk you through one specific case.""

If The listener needs a decision or action

End on one clean next step.

""So the next step is to keep one backup supplier on file.""

If The listener is already clear

Stop — don't finish the structure for its own sake.

""Sounds like you've got what you need, so I'll leave it there.""

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Compress it to one sentence per step so the contribution stays concise and memorable. — *""Quick example: supplier pulled out, I owned delivery, I lined up three alternatives, we shipped on time.""*

Job interview

Lead with a real example, keep the scene short, and land a concrete result. — *""You asked for a time I handled pressure — here's one.""*

Email or written update

Lay it out as labelled or bulleted paragraphs so it can be scanned. — *""Context, what I did, and the outcome are in the three short paragraphs below.""*

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback is wanted before you structure it. — *""Would a specific example be useful here, or do you want the headline first?""*

Difficult conversation

One sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — *""Here's what happened and what I did — then I'll stop and hear you.""*

Performance review

Use STAR to give evidence for a claim about your work. — *""When I say I improved retention, here's the specific example.""*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Live conflict, where a tidy structure can feel cold
- Vulnerable disclosure that needs listening, not a framework
- When the person needs a direct answer, not a story
- Emotionally charged moments — distress, shame, grief or anger
- A real power imbalance, where a set-piece answer can feel evasive
- High-stakes decisions that need open discussion, not a rehearsed case
- Physical safety or an emergency, where structure wastes time

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Pick a story

Choose one real experience that shows a skill you want to evidence, and jot down its four parts: Situation, Task, Action, Result.

Day 2 — Write it out

Draft a 60-second STAR response for that example in full sentences.

Day 3 — Cut by a third

Trim it hard — shrink the situation to a sentence, protect the action and result, and remove anything that isn't carrying weight.

Day 4 — Say it two ways

Read it aloud once with the labels announced, once as plain speech. Keep whichever sounds like a person, not a template.

Day 5 — Make it scannable

Rewrite the same example as a short email — labelled or bulleted — so a reader could skim it in ten seconds.

Day 6 — Use it live

Drop the example into a real conversation and watch whether the listener gets clearer, asks a sharper question, or can act.

Day 7 — Recover and set a default

Practise one recovery line for when it lands too structured, and pick your default length: one-line, 30-second, or two-minute.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use STAR to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear by the end?
- Did I keep the scene short and spend most of the time on action and result?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve the other person's autonomy and dignity?
- Did it sound like me, or like a memorised template?